

World in Brief: Supreme Court gives Trump new powers; Iran denies planned talks



Photograph: Alamy

America's **Supreme Court** granted **Donald Trump** sweeping powers to sack the heads of independent government agencies. However, the ruling does not apply to the Federal Reserve, helping to preserve the central bank's independence. In a separate decision [the justices](#) also blocked Mr Trump's [attempt to fire Lisa Cook](#), a Fed governor, ruling that his justification for her dismissal was too weak.

Iran said there were no planned talks with **America** in Qatar this week, seemingly contradicting claims by the Trump administration. The two countries' [ceasefire](#) was rattled by an exchange of strikes over the weekend. Meanwhile Iran's deputy foreign minister asserted that Iran was "solely" in charge of [demining](#) the **Strait of Hormuz**; France had earlier announced it would "collaborate" on the task with Oman and others.

Andy Burnham began to set out [his policy agenda](#) as he bids to become **Britain's** prime minister. The former mayor of Greater Manchester pledged to gradually increase "public control" of utilities, boost local-government funding and shift power over economic policy away from London. Markets moved little,

reassured by Mr Burnham's repeated commitment to the fiscal rules set out by Sir Keir Starmer's government.

Comcast said it will split into two separate companies, spinning off its media and entertainment arm from its broadband and wireless-network division. The media arm, which contains **NBCUniversal** and **Sky**, is thought to have been dragging on the share price as it has faced rising competition from [streaming upstarts like Netflix](#). Comcast's shares rose by more than 20% in premarket trading after the announcement.

The **European Union's** investment arm agreed to lend €3bn (\$3.4bn) to **Airbus** to support the aerospace giant's investments in industries such as defence. Officials hope to reduce reliance on America and China. Airbus has recently been lobbying the **EU** to approve a tie-up with Leonardo and Thales, two other European defence firms, in which they will combine their space divisions to make a new company.

Pakistan said it killed 29 militants near its border with **Afghanistan** in reprisal for "multiple terrorist incidents" in recent days. Afghanistan's Taliban government said at least 36 civilians had been killed in the strikes, with 163 injured, in what it called an "act of brutality". Pakistan accuses Afghanistan [of sheltering hostile fighters](#), including the Tehreek-e-Taliban Pakistan, a militia that frequently targets Pakistani soldiers and police.

Rocket Lab, an American rocket firm, said it will buy **Iridium**, a satellite-maker, in a \$8bn cash-and-stock deal. The rocket-maker hopes the merger could help it compete with [Elon Musk's SpaceX](#) and its satellite network, Starlink. But that is no small undertaking. Starlink consists of more than 10,000 satellites; Iridium controls fewer than 100. The share prices of Rocket Lab and Iridium jumped on the news.

Figure of the day: \$9bn, the value of Chinese divestments from American renewables since 2025. [Read about how](#) Donald Trump is chasing Chinese firms out of the country.

Correction: In yesterday's edition a chart showing Paraguay's gross fixed capital formation should have been in trillions of guaraníes rather than millions. Sorry.

Trump's faltering plan for Gaza



Photograph: Getty Images

Donald Trump's Board of Peace for Gaza meets on Tuesday in Cyprus to assess the situation in the strip, nearly nine months after the ceasefire between Israel and Hamas. Mr Trump's much vaunted attempt to replace the United Nations has little to show for itself. Israel still occupies most of the strip; more than a thousand Gazans have been killed since the ceasefire began. Hamas remains entrenched and armed. Urgently needed reconstruction has yet to begin.

There have been some minor developments, such as the appointment of a Palestinian technocratic administration (its members are still stuck in Cairo), an agreement by a handful of countries to send troops to the enclave as part of an international security force, and an Emirati pledge to rebuild neighbourhoods in southern Gaza. But those are yet to bring change on the ground. And not much else is likely to get done while Israel's government is preoccupied by an [election campaign](#), which is set to last until the winter.

Nike's swoosh swoons



Photograph: Reuters

If popular adverts alone could make a brand successful, Nike, which reports earnings on Tuesday, would be a winner. The [American sportswear giant](#) kicked off the World Cup with a video featuring stars such as France's Kylian Mbappé and Portugal's Cristiano Ronaldo dribbling their way through elaborate film sets. The clip has 78m views on YouTube, ten times the number of a video by Adidas, a rival.

Yet behind such triumphs lie Nike's recent struggles. Its share price has been tumbling since February, when it warned investors to expect a 20% fall in sales in China, where competition among makers of footwear fierce, in the fourth quarter. Worldwide, Nike's sales have declined in seven of the past eight quarters. [The World Cup](#) may interrupt the downward trend. But analysts will be scrutinising Nike's results for signs that its multi-year turnaround strategy will provide a more enduring boost to its fortunes. A viral video alone will not return Nike to winning ways.

Just can't do it

Nike, share price, \$



Source: LSEG Workspace

A prompt prognosis of China's economy



Photograph: Getty Images

Most countries have to wait until the first working day of the month for a purchasing-managers' index, a timely indicator of economic activity over the past month, based on surveys of procurement bosses in hundreds of firms. But China's speedy National Bureau of Statistics typically releases its [manufacturing PMI](#) before the month is even over.

The June reading, released on Tuesday, will probably remain around 50 out of 100. That is supposed to represent the dividing line between expansion and contraction. In practice, over the past ten years, that figure has lined up with robust [industrial-production growth](#) of roughly 6% at an annualised pace (excluding the first months of the covid-19 pandemic). The index will also reveal whether falling oil prices have eased input costs, which spiked after the start of the Iran war. The Chinese government gets its statistics out in a hurry. It would like peace talks in the Gulf to show similar urgency.

Ukraine's North Korean captives



Photograph: AP

Ukraine's foreign minister, Andrii Sybiha, heads to Seoul on Tuesday to meet Cho Hyun, his South Korean counterpart. They will talk about the fate of North Korean soldiers who were captured by Ukraine [while fighting for Russia](#). They are seeking asylum in South Korea, fearing that they will be tortured if they return to the North. In such cases, international human-rights law prohibits forced repatriation. The South Korean government has said the country will accept all North Korean prisoners-of-war.

North Korea's dictatorial regime sent more than 10,000 people to fight Ukraine in Russia's Kursk region. Thousands were killed. North Korean soldiers were instructed to "self-blast" on the battlefield to avoid capture. Russia has suggested that North Koreans should be included in its prisoner swaps with Ukraine. That would be a tempting offer, if Ukraine could get more of its soldiers back in return. But sending the North Koreans back to Russia would weaken international support for Ukraine. Odds are, the North Koreans will eventually head to the South.

South Africa's intensifying anti-migrant violence



Photograph: Getty Images

Concern is growing in South Africa's government that [anti-migrant protests](#) will reach a violent climax on Tuesday. March and March, a vigilante group, has set the day as a “deadline” by which illegal immigrants must leave. It has also pledged to take to the streets again. The group's protests focus on poor urban areas. It goes door to door, asking Africans for proof of their immigration status. Many shops run by foreigners have been looted.

The vigilantes reflect—and exacerbate—xenophobia among the public. Polling suggests that growing numbers of South Africans say that immigrants take away jobs and cause crime (economists generally disagree). Anti-foreigner sentiment is being stoked by online activists and many politicians: UMkhonto weSizwe (MK), a party founded by Jacob Zuma, South Africa's former president, has expressed support for March and March's protests. The security services seem prepared for violence. Yet even if they contain damage on the day, South Africa's brand on the continent is tarnished.

Daily quiz



Illustration: Sandra Navarro

We will serve you a new question each weekday. On Friday your challenge is to give us all five answers and tell us the theme. Email your responses (and your home city and country) by 1700 BST on Friday to [\[email protected\]](#). We'll pick three winners at random and crown them on Saturday.

Tuesday: Which actor played Roseanne Barr's husband in the sitcom Roseanne?

Monday: Which businessman, currently chief executive of Square, was a co-founder of Twitter?

*I cannot and will not cut my
conscience to fit this year's
fashions.*

Lillian Hellman